

ZERO SUM RPG SCENARIO: THE BLACKOUT RANSOM

REAL-WORLD INSPIRATION

This scenario is heavily anonymized but conceptually derived from current worldwide events regarding: **Grid hackers threatening to freeze a city in winter**. It integrates modern digital demagogue mechanics and corporate overreach.

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1. THE HOOK

The players are contracted to infiltrate a highly secure Power Grid Control Center. An influential **Political Streamer** has weaponized their parasocial swarm of millions of followers to act as an unwitting shield for an illegal operation happening inside. The authorities will not intervene out of fear of a massive PR disaster and riots.

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2. THE DIGITAL DEMAGOGUE

The primary antagonist isn't a heavily armed warlord, but an influencer who commands attention. They don't use guns; they use live-streams. If the players are detected, the influencer will immediately broadcast their faces, instantly raising the Social Heat to maximum and doxxing them globally.

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3. THE COMPLICATION

Violence is not an option here. *Alternatively, the players can leverage Deep Cover to bypass the guard entirely by passing a DC 2 Subterfuge check. **The target is dead-man switched to the grid; killing them triggers the blackout.*** If a single shot is fired, the Dead Man's Zone rule applies, and the players will face an impossible extraction against overwhelming force.

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4. ZERO SUM CONSISTENCY MATRIX (ZSCM)

To ensure the scenario maintains the brutal asymmetry of the *Zero Sum* system, the ZSCM values are pre-calculated:

- **Antagonist Power (E):** 5/10
- **Player Starting Resources (R):** 6/10
- **Initial Intel Asymmetry (I):** 7/10
- **Collateral Damage Risk (D):** 6/10
- **Total Stress Score:** 24/30 (Valid: Mechanically Solvable but Asymmetric)

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5. OBJECTIVES & EXTRACTION

1. **Infiltrate:** Bypass the physical security without alerting the follower swarm.
2. **Isolate:** Disconnect the influencer from the global network to stop the broadcast threat.
3. **Extract:** Secure the objective data and vanish before the algorithmic police response arrives.